DIGITALAIKART · PREMIUM INDIA EDITION

THE 2026 WORK & CAREER PLAYBOOK SERIES

The AI HR & Recruitment Playbook 2026

India Edition · 100+ copy-paste prompts for hiring, onboarding and people work — plus the DPDP toolkit

- 100+ prompts across 10 HR jobs
- The evidence-and-quote screening method
- DPDP Act & Rules 2025 compliance toolkit
- Bias guardrails + a 30-day adoption plan

Verified against official sources · October 2026

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Before you start

Read This First

This playbook is written for one person: an Indian HR professional, recruiter, or small-business owner who hires — and who has been told to “use AI” without being told how to do it safely. It is deliberately short on theory and long on prompts you can copy, paste and use in the next ten minutes. Every adoption figure, tool price and legal date below was checked against official sources, government notifications and current vendor pricing in October 2026.

Two honest warnings before you start. First, AI drafts — you decide. An AI asked to give a candidate a “fit score” with no rubric is, in the words of one 2026 HR guide, “a random number generator with good grammar.” Give it a written rubric with quoted evidence, keep the judgement with a named human, and never let it auto-reject anyone. Second, candidate data is personal data. Under India’s DPDP Act 2023 and the DPDP Rules 2025, a résumé, an application form, an interview recording and a scorecard are all personal data, and most compliance duties land by 13 May 2027. This guide gives you the prompts and the compliance habits together, so you build the right thing from day one.

> **This is education, not legal advice**
> Nothing here is legal advice and no tool is recommended for you personally. Data protection law is fact-specific. Use the checklists and prompts, and involve your legal or compliance team (or a qualified lawyer) before you finalise a consent notice, a retention policy, or any automated screening decision.

What is inside

1. The 2026 reality: where Indian HR really is with AI
2. The prompt formula and the 10 safety rules
3. The prompt library — 100+ copy-paste prompts across 10 jobs
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7. Your 30-day adoption plan

Appendix A — Fill-in templates · Appendix B — Cheat sheet, glossary and FAQ

Chapter 1

The 2026 Reality: Where Indian HR Really Is With AI

India did not dabble with AI in hiring — it jumped in. By 2026 the country leads the world in recruitment-AI adoption, and the gap between the hype and the daily reality is where this playbook lives.

The numbers you can quote in a meeting

Finding	Figure	Source (2026)
Indian organisations say AI or agentic AI is transforming recruitment	86%	Deloitte India, Campus Workforce Trends 2026
Resume screening named as the leading AI use case	72%	Deloitte India, Campus Workforce Trends 2026
Indian employers actively using AI in hiring (highest globally)	95%	Indeed, Smarter Hiring Report
Indian recruiters say AI helped surface candidates they would have missed	71%	LinkedIn recruiter survey
Recruiters who feel pressure to explain how AI is used in hiring	50%	LinkedIn recruiter survey
HR leaders who cite data privacy and compliance as the top barrier to GenAI	51%	BCG, Creating People Advantage 2026
Organisations using AI in HR that lack, or only partly have, an AI policy	19%	SHRM India, HR Priorities with AI

Read those two lines together and you have the whole problem. Adoption is near-universal, but half of recruiters cannot explain how the AI is being used, and half of leaders name privacy and compliance as the single biggest obstacle. Most teams have the tool and not the method.

What AI is genuinely good at in HR — and what it is not

- Good at: turning a rough brief into a first-draft job description, generating screening and interview questions, structuring messy notes, summarising a funnel, drafting candidate messages, and rephrasing policy in plain language.
- Bad at: judging a person. Communication, attitude, potential and culture fit are human calls — in Indeed’s 2026 survey, 77% of Indian candidates said those qualities need a human to assess them properly.
- Actively risky at: scoring or ranking candidates with no written rubric, ‘auto-rejecting’ on an AI score, and feeding résumés containing names, photos and contact details into a public chatbot.

> **The one rule that runs through this whole guide**
> AI drafts, a human decides. Keep a written rubric, demand quoted evidence, and keep the final rejection with a named person. Everything else in this playbook is a detail of that one rule.

Chapter 2

The Prompt Formula and the 10 Safety Rules

A vague prompt gets a vague answer. Before the library, learn the shape that makes every prompt in this book work — and the ten rules that keep you out of trouble.

The five-part prompt formula

1. Role — tell the AI who it is: “You are an experienced HR business partner in an Indian mid-size IT services company.”
2. Context — give the real material: the role, the team, the location, the constraints, the problem. Paste the JD or the notes, not a summary of them.
3. Task — state the single job: “Write five pre-screening questions that separate genuinely qualified candidates from those who only read the ad.”
4. Constraints — the guardrails: length, tone, what to avoid (gendered language, qualification inflation), and what to do when it cannot answer (“write NOT COVERED and stop”).
5. Format — the output shape: a table with named columns, bullet points, a 50-word summary, JSON.

Every prompt in Chapter 3 already follows this shape. You only replace the bracketed parts.

The 10 safety rules

- 1. Anonymise before you paste. Strip names, photos, phone numbers, emails and addresses from any résumé or note that goes into a public AI tool. The AI does not need them to help you.
- 2. Use a business or API account for real candidate data, not a personal free chatbot, wherever your organisation allows it. Check your company’s AI policy first — and if there isn’t one, that is the first thing to write.
- 3. Never auto-reject. AI may rank and surface evidence; the rejection decision stays with a named human, and you must be able to show why.
- 4. Demand evidence and quotes. Ask for a score plus the exact sentence from the source that justifies it, and force a null when no such sentence exists.
- 5. Write the rubric before the prompt. Criteria first, scoring second — never the other way round.
- 6. Disclose AI use. Tell candidates that AI assists in initial review; a plain line in the application process is enough and is becoming expected.
- 7. Pin the source. Give the AI the JD or the policy document and require every claim to map to it.
- 8. Flag bias on purpose. Ask the model to flag gendered language, qualification inflation and criteria that risk unfairness, and act on what it finds.
- 9. Keep an audit trail. Log, per candidate, the criteria used, the score, the source text and the model version, so any decision is defensible.
- 10. No protected data in the prompt. Do not enter health, caste, religion, marital status, pregnancy or similar details, and keep any diversity data separate from the hiring decision.

The prompt that fixes most bad AI output
“For each criterion, return a score of 0, 1 or 2, and the exact sentence from the source that justifies the score. If no such sentence exists, score 0 and set the quote to NULL.” This single instruction turns a guess into something you can defend.

Chapter 3

The Prompt Library — 100+ Copy-Paste Prompts

Replace every bracket with your own detail. Paste résumés and notes only after anonymising them, and never enter a candidate's contact details, photo or sensitive personal data. The prompts are grouped by the ten jobs Indian HR teams do most.

A. Job descriptions and sourcing

Job description from a rough brief

You are an experienced HR business partner at a [industry] company of [size] employees in [city], India. Write a job description for a [job title] reporting to [reporting line]. The five things the hiring manager actually cares about are: [point 1], [point 2], [point 3], [point 4], [point 5]. Every requirement you list must map to one of those five — delete any requirement that maps to nothing. Format: role summary (50 words), responsibilities (6 bullets), must-have skills (5 bullets), nice-to-have (3 bullets), what we offer (3 bullets). Avoid gendered language and qualification inflation.

Inclusive-language review of a JD

Review this job description for language that may discourage qualified candidates from applying. Check for: gendered or masculine-coded words; qualification inflation; experience requirements that exclude non-traditional backgrounds; culture-fit language that signals exclusivity; and jargon only insiders would understand. For each issue, quote the exact phrase and give a specific replacement. Then output the corrected JD. [PASTE JD]

Map every JD requirement to an interview stage

Here is a job description: [PASTE JD]. For each listed requirement, name the interview stage that actually tests it (screen, technical round, behavioural round, take-home, reference). If a requirement is not tested at any stage, list it under a heading "Delete these" with a one-line reason.

Boolean search string for a role

Create a Boolean search string to find [job title] candidates in [city], India with [skill 1], [skill 2] and under [N] years of experience. Include synonyms for the title and the skills, and explain each operator you use.

LinkedIn X-ray search

Write a LinkedIn X-ray search (a Google query restricted to linkedin.com/in) to find [role] professionals in India who have worked at [type of company, e.g. product startups]. Give the exact query and a short note on how to vary it for a different seniority.

Short job ad for WhatsApp and Instagram

Turn this job description into a 60-word ad for a WhatsApp broadcast and an Instagram caption. Lead with the most attractive fact, keep it in simple English, add a clear "apply here" line, and suggest 5 relevant hashtags. [PASTE JD]

Career-page JD rewrite for culture

Rewrite this job description for our careers page so it sounds like a real team, not a legal notice. Keep every requirement, keep it honest, use short sentences, and add one paragraph on what the first 90 days look like. [PASTE JD]

Requirement inflation audit

Here is a job description: [PASTE JD]. List every requirement, then mark each one as ESSENTIAL or INFLATED. For every INFLATED item, say in one line what a realistic version would be, and whether the role could be done without it.

Sourcing message to a passive candidate

Write a LinkedIn InMail (under 120 words) to a passive [role] candidate whose profile shows [specific detail]. Be specific, not flattering. Open with why their background fits, state the role and location in one line, and close with a low-pressure question. Do not be pushy or apologetic.

Referral request to current employees

Write a short internal message asking employees to refer candidates for our open [role]. Explain the referral process, what makes a strong fit (3 points), and the referral reward if we have one: [reward]. Keep it friendly and under 120 words.

Search-optimised job title

For a role that we internally call “[internal title]”, suggest 5 job titles that candidates actually search on Naukri and LinkedIn in India. For each, note who it attracts and any downside. Recommend one.

Skills-first JD rewrite

Rewrite this JD to focus on demonstrated skills and outcomes instead of years of experience and college pedigree. Keep the same role. [PASTE JD]

Competitor JD teardown

Here are three job ads for a [role] from companies we compete with for talent: [PASTE]. Compare them on clarity, requirements, and appeal. Tell me what they offer that we do not, and draft three lines for our ad that would make a strong candidate stop and read.

B. Screening and shortlisting

Structure a résumé into fixed fields

You are a résumé parsing assistant. From the résumé text below, extract ONLY what is explicitly stated — do not infer or evaluate. Output these fields: current role and employer; total years of relevant experience (from the dates given); key skills; tools and technologies; education and certifications; and notable achievements with their exact metrics. If a field is not stated, write NOT STATED. [PASTE ANONYMISED RÉSUMÉ]

The evidence-and-quote scoring rubric

Score this anonymised résumé against the criteria below. For each criterion return: a score of 0, 1 or 2 (0 = no evidence, 1 = partial, 2 = strong specific evidence), the exact sentence from the résumé that justifies the score, and a NULL if no such sentence exists. Do not give an overall hiring recommendation. Criteria: [criterion 1], [criterion 2], [criterion 3]. [PASTE ANONYMISED RÉSUMÉ]

Build a weighted scoring rubric

You are an HR professional shortlisting for a [job title]. Based on these requirements: [PASTE REQUIREMENTS], create a weighted scoring rubric with 6–8 criteria. For each: the criterion name, what MEETS expectations looks like, what EXCEEDS looks like, and a suggested weight (the weights must total 100%). Format as a table. Then flag any criterion where unconscious-bias risk is high and say why.

Skill mapping from a résumé

From this résumé, extract every skill, tool and competency mentioned, wherever it appears. Group them into: Technical skills; Tools and platforms; Soft skills. Do not rate proficiency or relevance. [PASTE ANONYMISED RÉSUMÉ]

Experience timeline with gaps flagged

Build a clean month-by-month timeline of this candidate’s roles and education from the résumé text, and mark any gap of three months or more. Do not interpret the gaps — just show them. [PASTE ANONYMISED RÉSUMÉ]

Red-flag scan (use with care)

From this anonymised résumé, list anything a careful recruiter would want to verify in a conversation — unclear dates, unexplained gaps, claims without evidence, or mismatches between title and described work. Present each as a neutral question to ask, not a judgement. [PASTE ANONYMISED RÉSUMÉ]

JD-to-résumé gap analysis

Compare this résumé against this JD. Output a table: requirement | evidence in résumé (quote) | meets / partial / no evidence. Do not decide the outcome. [PASTE JD] [PASTE ANONYMISED RÉSUMÉ]

Shortlist summary table

Here are anonymised summaries of [N] candidates for a [role]. Build a comparison table with one row per candidate and columns for each criterion in this rubric: [criteria]. Fill only from the summaries; write NOT STATED where the summary is silent. Add a final column ‘evidence quality’ (high / medium / low). Do not rank or recommend.

Review a portfolio or GitHub for a tech role

Here is the text from a candidate’s portfolio/GitHub README: [PASTE]. Against this JD: [PASTE], list which requirements the public work demonstrates, which it does not, and two specific questions to ask in the interview to fill the gaps.

Practical pre-screening questions

Based on this job description: [PASTE JD], write 5 pre-screening questions that distinguish genuinely qualified candidates from those who only read the ad. They must be practical and scenario-based, answerable in under 200 words, and include at least one that reveals how the person thinks.

Normalise messy application data

Here are [N] candidate records pasted from different sources: [PASTE]. Standardise them into one table with columns: name-free ID, role applied for, years of experience, key skills, location, notice period, current CTC (as stated). Keep original wording for anything you cannot cleanly convert, and do not invent values.

Compare two candidates on evidence only

Compare candidate A and candidate B on these criteria: [criteria]. For each criterion, show the evidence each one provides (quote it) and which is stronger and why. End with ‘What a human must still decide’ listing the judgements the evidence cannot settle.

Batch-screen and surface only the strongest

Here are [N] anonymised candidate summaries for a [role]: [PASTE]. Score each against this rubric: [criteria], using the evidence-and-quote method. Then return only the candidates who score above [threshold], with their evidence, and list the rest as ‘below threshold — human review optional’. Do not reject anyone.

C. Interviews

Structured interview guide

You are an HR manager preparing an interview for a [job title]. The candidate has [N] years of experience in [function]. Create a structured guide with: 3 competency-based questions assessing [competency 1], [competency 2] and [competency 3]; 2 situational STAR-format questions on [key challenge]; 1 culture-fit question about [team value]; and a follow-up probe for each. Format as a table: Question | What to listen for | Follow-up probe.

Behavioural STAR question set

Write 5 behavioural interview questions for a [role] using the STAR method, each targeting one of these competencies: [list]. For each, add what a strong answer contains and what a rehearsed or vague answer sounds like.

Technical questions with model answers

Write 6 role-specific technical questions for a [role] in [domain]. For each, include what the question tests and what a strong answer looks like. Keep them practical, not trivia that can be Googled in one search.

Culture-fit questions that are not exclusionary

Write 4 culture-fit questions for a [role] on a [team type] team. They must assess how someone works, not whether they ‘fit in’ socially. Avoid any question that could disadvantage a candidate by background, gender, region or language.

Follow-up probes for generic answers

A candidate answered “[generic answer]” to “[question]”. Give me 4 follow-up probes that push for specific, verifiable detail, and tell me what each probe is really trying to establish.

Ambiguity and thinking question

Write one interview question that reveals how a [role] candidate thinks under ambiguity — a realistic situation with incomplete information and no single right answer. Include how to tell a strong answer from a weak one.

Interviewer briefing document

Create a one-page interviewer briefing for a [job title] interview. Include: the role in two lines, the three competencies to assess, the questions to ask (no repeats across panellists), the scorecard, the legal dos and don’ts (no questions about age, marriage, children, caste, religion or health), and the decision timeline.

Interview scorecard

Build a one-page interview scorecard for a [role] with the criteria [list]. Columns: criterion | score 1–5 | evidence/quote | concerns. Add a section for ‘strengths’ and ‘areas to probe further’, and a line for the interviewer to sign.

Split questions across a panel

We have a [N]-person interview panel for a [role]: [panellist roles]. Assign the interview questions so each competency is covered once with no repeats, and give each panellist a 2-line brief on what to assess. Questions to allocate: [PASTE QUESTIONS].

Turn raw notes into evidence

Here are my raw interview notes for a candidate: [PASTE NOTES]. Regroup them under these competencies: [list]. Where the notes contain a contradiction (e.g. ‘strong ownership’ but ‘waited for sign-off twice’), flag it rather than averaging it away. Do not add anything that is not in the notes.

Take-home assignment brief

Write a take-home assignment brief for a [role] that can be completed in [time, e.g. 3 hours]. Include the scenario, the deliverable, the evaluation criteria, what we are NOT looking for, and a note that we will not use the candidate's work commercially.

Reference-check questions

Write 5 reference-check questions for a [role] candidate. They must be factual and work-related, avoid personal or protected-characteristic topics, and include one question that tests reliability and one that tests how the person handles disagreement.

Case-study question for a senior role

Write a case-study interview question for a senior [role] that reflects a realistic challenge in [domain]. Include the scenario, the information to give the candidate, the questions to ask, and the criteria that separate a strong answer from a shallow one.

D. Candidate communication

Warm first reply to an applicant

Write a warm but efficient first reply to a candidate who applied for our [role]. Thank them, state the next step and the timeline, and set the expectation clearly. Under 100 words, simple English, no false promises.

Interview invitation with prep tips

Write an interview invitation email for a [role] interview on [date] at [time] via [mode]. Include the panel, the format, how long it will take, 3 short prep tips, and what to bring. Friendly and clear.

Interview reminder

Write a reminder message (email or WhatsApp) for an interview tomorrow at [time]. Confirm the mode and link/address, restate one prep tip, and give a contact for questions. Under 70 words.

Reschedule message

Write a message rescheduling a candidate’s interview from [old date] to [new date], offering two alternative slots. Apologise briefly, do not over-explain, and make it easy for them to pick a slot.

Rejection after the screening stage

Write a kind, firm rejection email for a candidate who was screened out for a [role]. Thank them for the effort, keep it short, do not give a detailed critique, and leave the door open for future roles. Under 90 words.

Rejection after the final round

Write a rejection email for a candidate who reached the final round for a [role] but was not selected. Acknowledge the effort and time, give one honest and constructive line of feedback if appropriate, and offer to stay in touch. Warm and respectful, under 130 words.

Offer letter draft

Draft an offer letter for a [role] at [company], [city], with CTC of [amount], a start date of [date], reporting to [name/role], and a [N]-month probation. Include the key terms in plain language and a placeholder for the formal annexure. Note that this is a draft for your legal team to review.

Salary discussion opener

Write a short, professional message to open the compensation conversation with a candidate for a [role], where our budget is [range]. Ask for their expectation without anchoring too low, and keep the tone collaborative.

Respond to a counter-offer

A candidate we want to hire has asked for [amount], above our offer of [amount]. Write a response that is honest about the budget, explains what we can offer beyond base pay ([points]), and asks what would make the offer work for them. No over-promising.

Welcome message on joining

Write a welcome message to a new [role] joining on [date]. Include who to contact on day one, what time to arrive, what to bring, and one line that makes them feel expected. Warm, under 120 words.

Thank-you note after an interview

Write a short thank-you note a recruiter can send after a good interview, keeping the candidate engaged while we finish other interviews. Honest, warm, no commitment to an outcome.

Feedback to an interviewed-but-not-selected candidate

Write a message giving a candidate who interviewed but was not selected one or two specific, useful pieces of feedback, framed constructively, with an invitation to reapply for a better-fit role. Do not invite a

debate about the decision.

Candidate FAQ auto-reply

Write short, polite auto-replies to the five questions candidates ask us most during hiring: [list questions]. Each answer must be accurate, set a clear expectation, and never promise an outcome. Keep each under 60 words.

E. Onboarding

30-60-90 day plan

Create a 30-60-90 day plan for a new [role] joining a [team type] team. For each phase, list the goals, the key tasks, who they should meet, and how success will be measured. Keep it realistic and specific to the role.

Day-one welcome email

Write a day-one welcome email from the manager to a new [role]. Include a short agenda for the first day, who they will meet, the first task, and an open invitation to ask questions. Friendly and specific.

First-week schedule

Build a first-week schedule for a new [role]. Include orientation, tool access, key introductions, one small win task, and a Friday check-in. Format as a day-by-day table.

Buddy or mentor brief

Write a brief for the buddy assigned to a new [role]. Explain their role, what to cover in week one, how to check in without hovering, and what to escalate to the manager. Under 200 words.

Role expectations document

Write a one-page ‘what success looks like’ document for a new [role], covering the first 90 days, the first year, and the three outcomes that matter most. Plain language, no jargon.

Training plan

Create a training plan for a new [role] over [N] weeks, covering the skills [list], with one deliverable per week and a way to check progress. Note what can be learned on the job versus what needs formal training.

Onboarding checklist

Create an onboarding checklist for a [role], split into Before Day 1, Day 1, Week 1 and Month 1. Include IT access, documentation, payroll and compliance items, and the human touchpoints.

Day-7 check-in message

Write a short day-7 check-in message from a manager to a new hire. Ask two specific questions about how it is going, offer help, and mention the 30-day review. Warm and brief.

30-day feedback conversation

Write a guide for a 30-day feedback conversation with a new [role]. Include 5 questions to ask, what to listen for, how to give one piece of constructive feedback, and how to close with clear next steps.

Onboarding experience survey

Write 8 questions for an onboarding experience survey sent at day 30. Mix rating and open-text questions, cover clarity of role, support received, tools and access, and one ‘what would have made week one better’ question.

F. Performance and feedback

SMART goals for a role

Write 5 SMART goals for a [role] for the next quarter, aligned to these business priorities: [priorities]. Each goal must have a measurable outcome and a realistic timeframe for an Indian workplace.

Draft OKRs for a team

Draft a set of OKRs for a [team] for the next quarter. Give 3 objectives, each with 3 measurable key results. Keep them outcome-based, not a task list.

Performance review draft from notes

Here are my notes on [employee role] over the last review period: [PASTE NOTES]. Draft a balanced performance review with sections for achievements, areas to develop, and goals for next period. Base every statement on the notes; do not invent examples.

Constructive feedback using the SBI model

Write a piece of constructive feedback using the Situation-Behaviour-Impact model for this case: [describe]. Keep it specific and respectful, and end with a clear, forward-looking ask.

Performance improvement plan

Draft a performance improvement plan for a [role] with the issue [describe]. Include the expected standard, the support we will provide, the review dates, and the consequences if the standard is not met. Neutral, documented tone. Note that your HR/legal team must review it before use.

1:1 meeting agenda

Create a repeatable 30-minute 1:1 agenda template for a manager and a [role]. Cover progress, blockers, growth, and feedback, with time boxes and 3 questions the manager should always ask.

Recognition and appreciation note

Write a short, specific appreciation note to an employee who [achievement]. Name the behaviour and its impact, keep it sincere, and avoid generic praise.

Difficult conversation script

Write a script for a difficult conversation with an employee about [issue]. Include an opening that is direct but kind, 3 questions to understand their side, how to state the concern clearly, and how to agree on next steps. Calm and professional.

Promotion case summary

Write a promotion case summary for [employee] from [current role] to [next role]. Include evidence of readiness against the next level, impact delivered, and a short development plan. Stick to what the evidence supports.

Self-appraisal coaching

Help an employee write their self-appraisal. Here is their raw input: [PASTE]. Turn it into a clear, confident summary with achievements, impact and goals, without exaggerating or inventing numbers.

G. Policies and compliance

Draft an HR policy

Draft a [policy name] policy for an Indian company of [size] employees. Include purpose, scope, the rules in plain language, roles and responsibilities, and a review date. Keep it practical, and add a note that it must be reviewed by legal before it is published.

Leave policy in plain language

Write a leave policy covering casual, sick and earned leave, public holidays, and the notice expectations, for a [size] company. Present it as a short employee-friendly summary plus a formal clause list. Do not state statutory figures you are unsure of — use [verify] placeholders.

Hybrid or work-from-home policy

Draft a hybrid-working policy for a [size] company: eligible roles, days in office, core hours, equipment, and how performance is managed remotely. Add a line on data security when working from home.

POSH awareness note

Write an internal awareness note on the Prevention of Sexual Harassment (POSH) framework for employees: what counts, how to report, the internal committee, and confidentiality. Keep it factual and non-legalistic, and mark it as awareness material that does not replace the official policy or legal advice.

Code-of-conduct summary

Summarise our code of conduct into a one-page employee version. Cover integrity, conflicts of interest, confidentiality, respectful behaviour, and how to raise a concern. Plain language, no jargon.

Handbook Q&A with clause citations

Using only the employee handbook text below, answer these questions: [questions]. For every answer, quote the clause number it came from. If the handbook does not cover a question, reply ‘Not covered in this document — escalate to HR’ and do not guess. [PASTE HANDBOOK]

DPDP candidate consent notice

Draft a standalone candidate consent notice for a hiring process. Include, in clear and simple language: the personal data we collect (itemised), the purpose of processing, how to withdraw consent, how to exercise rights, how to complain to the Data Protection Board, and the retention period. Offer it in English and one Indian language. Note that legal review is required before use.

Plain-language candidate privacy notice

Turn this privacy notice into a plain-language version a candidate can read in two minutes. Keep every legal point, cut the jargon, and keep it to one page. [PASTE NOTICE]

AI-use disclosure line for applications

Write a short, honest line to include in our application process telling candidates that AI tools assist in the initial review of applications, that a human makes every decision, and how to ask questions about it. Under 40 words.

Data retention and erasure note

Draft a short internal note on how long we keep candidate data and how we erase it once the hiring purpose is over. Include who is responsible, where the data is stored, and how an erasure request is handled. Use [verify] placeholders for any period your legal team must confirm.

Employee AI-use guideline note

Write a one-page guideline telling employees which AI tools they may use for work, what data may never be entered into them, how to check AI output before it is used, and who to ask when unsure. Plain language, no jargon.

H. Engagement and retention

Employee engagement survey

Write a 12-question employee engagement survey for a [size] company. Cover clarity, manager support, growth, recognition, workload and belonging. Use a 5-point scale plus two open-text questions, and keep every question anonymous-safe.

Five-question pulse survey

Write a 5-question monthly pulse survey. Each question must be answerable in under 15 seconds, and the set must surface one actionable signal. Include one open-text prompt.

Retention-risk analysis from signals

Here are anonymised signals for a team: [describe — e.g. engagement scores, overtime, tenure, recent 1:1 themes]. Identify the three roles most at risk of attrition and explain the reasoning in plain language. Suggest one low-cost retention action per role.

Stay-interview questions

Write 6 stay-interview questions to understand what keeps a valued [role] engaged and what might push them to leave. Open, non-defensive, and focused on the work, not on loyalty.

Exit-interview questions

Write 10 exit-interview questions for a [role] leaving. Cover the real reasons, the manager relationship, workload, pay, growth, and one ‘what should we fix first’ question. Keep the tone neutral and confidential.

Attrition-reason summary

Here are anonymised exit-interview notes from [N] leavers over the last [period]: [PASTE]. Summarise the top reasons in order, with the frequency of each, and note the single change that would address the most common reason.

Town-hall or announcement draft

Write a [topic] announcement for a company town hall of [size] people. Lead with the decision, explain the reason honestly, address the two questions employees will ask first, and end with next steps. No corporate jargon.

Internal newsletter blurb

Write a short internal newsletter blurb on [topic] for employees. Friendly, 120 words, with a clear takeaway and one call to action.

Manager listening-group questions

Write 6 questions a manager can use in a small listening-group session to understand what is working and what is not on the team. Open-ended, psychologically safe, and focused on things the manager can actually change.

I. Learning and development

Learning path for a role

Create a 3-month learning path for someone moving into a [role]. Break it into monthly themes, list the specific skills, name the type of resource for each (course, on-the-job task, mentor time), and give one deliverable per month.

Micro-learning topics

Suggest 8 micro-learning topics (10 minutes each) that would improve the productivity of a [team] in an Indian workplace. For each, give a one-line objective and a way to practise it.

Training session outline

Write a 60-minute training session outline on [topic] for [audience]. Include learning objectives, a timed agenda, one activity, and a short assessment.

Quiz questions for training

Write 10 quiz questions (with answers) to check understanding after a training session on [topic]. Mix multiple-choice and one short scenario question.

On-the-job assignment

Design a practical on-the-job assignment for someone learning [skill] in a [role]. Include the task, the success criteria, the support provided, and how it will be reviewed.

Upskilling ROI summary

Write a one-page summary for leadership on the expected return from upskilling our [team] in [skills]. Include the cost, the expected impact on [metric], the timeline, and how we will measure it. Be conservative and honest about uncertainty.

J. HR analytics and reporting

Recruitment funnel summary in plain English

Here is our hiring funnel data: [PASTE numbers — applications, screens, interviews, offers, joins]. Summarise it in plain English for a leadership update, show the conversion rate at each stage, and highlight the stage with the biggest drop-off.

Time-to-hire analysis

Here is time-to-hire data by role and stage: [PASTE]. Identify where the delay sits, compare roles against each other, and suggest two specific fixes that would shorten it without lowering quality.

Offer-acceptance-rate fixes

Our offer-acceptance rate is [X]% and declined offers were mostly for these reasons: [list]. Suggest five concrete, low-cost fixes, ranked by likely impact, and one thing to measure to check whether each is working.

Attrition analysis

Here is our attrition data for the last [period]: [PASTE]. Break it down by team, tenure and reason, identify the two patterns that matter most, and propose one action for each.

One-slide leadership update

Turn this HR data: [PASTE] into a single slide for a leadership meeting. Give a headline, three supporting points, one risk, and one ask. No more than 60 words in total.

Headcount and diversity dashboard summary

Summarise this headcount data: [PASTE] into a short dashboard narrative: total headcount, movement this period, and any diversity or inclusion signal worth flagging. Keep diversity data aggregated and never attribute it to individuals.

Chapter 4

The DPDP Compliance Toolkit for Hiring

This is the chapter most HR teams are missing. India's Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, and the DPDP Rules, 2025, apply squarely to hiring — and most day-to-day duties land in 2027. 2026 is the build year, and 51% of HR leaders already name privacy and compliance as their biggest AI barrier. Here is what you actually need to know, in order.

The timeline you are working towards

Date	What happens
11 August 2023	Parliament enacts the DPDP Act, 2023.
14 November 2025	The DPDP Rules, 2025 are notified; the Data Protection Board is established and its rules apply at once.
13 November 2026	Consent Managers must register with the Board (Rule 4).
13 May 2027	Most duties apply — notice, breach reporting, retention and erasure, children's data and Significant Data Fiduciary duties (Rules 3, 5–16, 22, 23).

The Rules give an 18-month phased-compliance window from November 2025. The practical reading: treat 2026 as the year you fix your candidate-data habits, before the duties become enforceable in mid-2027.

Why hiring is squarely in scope

The Act covers digital personal data processed in India — including data collected on paper and digitised later. A résumé, an application form, an interview recording, a transcript and a scorecard are all 'personal data'. The Act's employment clause (Section 7) lets organisations process data 'for the purposes of employment', but it names employees — it does not clearly mention candidates or recruitment. Commentators read that gap differently, so the cautious, defensible path is simple: give every candidate a clear notice, and get consent for anything a candidate would not expect from applying — recording an interview, running AI analysis, or keeping a profile for future roles.

> **The six habits that make hiring DPDP-ready**
> 1) A standalone, plain-language notice. 2) Consent that is free, specific, informed, unconditional and unambiguous, given by a clear affirmative action — no pre-ticked boxes. 3) Purpose limitation: use candidate data only for the hiring purpose. 4) Data minimisation: collect only what you need. 5) A retention and erasure rule — delete once the purpose is served. 6) Honour rights — access, correction and erasure — within 90 days.

The notice must actually say these things

- The personal data being collected and the purpose of processing, described item by item.
- How to withdraw consent, with withdrawal as easy as giving it, and how to use the grievance route.
- How to complain to the Data Protection Board of India.
- The retention period, and disclosure of any automated decision-making (including profiling) with an explanation where the outcome is significant.

- Whether a data processor is engaged, or others the data will be shared with.
- It must be standalone (not buried in terms), in clear plain language, and offered in English or any of the 22 languages in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution.

What the penalties look like

Failure	Maximum penalty
Failing to take reasonable security safeguards	₹250 crore
Failing to notify the Board or affected people of a breach	₹200 crore
Breaching the duties on children’s data	₹200 crore
Any other breach of the Act or Rules by a Data Fiduciary	₹50 crore

The Act does not cap penalties across multiple breaches — each can attract a separate fine. That is the reason compliance belongs in your hiring workflow now, not in a panic later.

AI-specific compliance rules of thumb

- Disclose AI use in screening. A simple line in the application process — ‘we use AI tools to assist in the initial review of applications’ — is becoming the expected norm.
- Keep screening explainable. For any candidate, you should be able to export the criteria used, the score per criterion, the source text behind each score, and the model version.
- Human review before rejection. Never auto-reject on an AI score; keep the decision with a named human, and give borderline cases a human look.
- If you hire for roles based in the EU, note the EU AI Act treats CV-sorting and recruitment AI as high-risk. Those obligations were deferred by the AI Omnibus to 2 December 2027 for stand-alone high-risk systems — still a reason to build the documentation habit now.

Chapter 5

Bias and Fairness: The Guardrails

AI does not remove bias — it can amplify whatever is in your criteria and your historical data. The good news is that the fix is not complicated, and most of it is already in the prompts you just read.

How bias gets into an AI hiring process

- An open-ended ‘ideal candidate’ prompt with no rubric — the model mirrors patterns from its training data instead of your needs.
- Historical data: if past hires were not diverse, a model trained on them will favour similar profiles.
- Language in the JD that quietly narrows the pool — research cited by HR tooling vendors suggests inclusive job descriptions attract materially more applications.
- Criteria that are proxies for protected characteristics — e.g. ‘culture fit’, a specific college, or an unnecessary language requirement.

The five guardrails

1. Write the rubric before the prompt, with 6–8 weighted criteria and evidence anchors for each score level.
2. Force evidence and quotes — a score with no source sentence is set to NULL.
3. Audit the language: run the inclusive-JD review prompt on every ad before it goes live.
4. Keep protected attributes out of the decision and the prompt — collect any diversity data separately, aggregate it, and never attach it to a candidate’s file.
5. Review the distribution: periodically check whether scores differ across groups and whether any criterion is doing more work than it should. If something looks off, fix the criterion, not the candidate.

The bias-flag prompt you should run every time
Add this to any screening prompt: ‘Flag any criterion in this rubric where unconscious-bias risk is high, and suggest a fairer, job-related version of it.’ It costs one line and catches the most common problems before they reach a candidate.

Chapter 6

The Tool Stack in India, October 2026

You do not need a special HR AI. Any capable general assistant does the prompts in this book — what matters is which plan you buy, how you pay, and what data you are allowed to put in it. These are the verified India prices as of October 2026.

Tool and plan	Price in India	Notes
ChatGPT Go	₹399 / month	Cheapest paid tier; UPI autopay accepted; GST included.
ChatGPT Plus	₹1,999 / month	Stronger reasoning and longer tasks; GST included.
Google AI Plus (Gemini)	₹399 / month	Doubles free-tier limits; video generation included.
Google AI Pro (Gemini)	₹1,950 / month	Higher limits, Deep Research, larger context. Free for 18 months for eligible Jio users on an unlimited 5G plan of ₹349+.
Claude Pro	US$20 / month (about ₹1,999 in the iPhone app)	Billed in dollars on the website — expect a forex markup; rupee price in the app.
Perplexity Pro	US$20 / month (about ₹1,999 in the iPhone app)	Good for research and sourcing; rupee price in the app.
Free tiers	₹0	Every major assistant has a usable free plan — fine for drafting, not for real candidate data.

Choose by data, not by features

- Drafting and brainstorming (no real candidate data): a free or ₹399 plan is plenty.
- Working with anonymised candidate data: a paid consumer plan is usually acceptable if your company policy allows it.
- Working with identifiable candidate data: use a business, API or enterprise plan with a data processing agreement, or an India-hosted HR platform — not a personal free chatbot.
- Before you pay anyone on Jio: check MyJio first — eligible users get 18 months of Google AI Pro free, which is the best value available in India right now.

> **The habit that matters more than the tool**
> Anonymise before you paste. If a résumé goes into an AI tool, it goes in with the name, photo, phone number, email and address removed. That single habit keeps you safer than any subscription you can buy.

Chapter 7

Your 30-Day Adoption Plan

Week 1 — Set the rules

- Write (or find) your AI-in-HR policy: what tools are allowed, what data may never be entered, and who owns decisions. If you have no policy, draft one — 19% of AI-using organisations do not have a solid one.
- Agree the one rule out loud with your team: AI drafts, a human decides; no auto-rejection, ever.
- Pick your tool and plan using the Chapter 6 table; check the Jio offer before paying.

Week 2 — Fix the basics

- Run the inclusive-JD review prompt on your three most-used job descriptions and publish the fixed versions.
- Build one weighted scoring rubric for your highest-volume role, with evidence anchors.
- Add the AI-use disclosure line to your application process.

Week 3 — Put the prompts to work

- Use the evidence-and-quote prompt to screen a live batch of anonymised résumés, and compare its output against your own shortlist.
- Run the structured-interview-guide prompt for your next interview and brief the panel with it.
- Start the audit-trail log: per candidate, the criteria, the score, the source and the model version.

Week 4 — Make it stick

- Draft your candidate consent notice and privacy notice using the Chapter 4 checklists — then send them to legal for review.
- Write your retention and erasure rule, and note where candidate data lives.
- Run one HR analytics prompt (funnel or time-to-hire) and take a single insight to your leadership meeting.

Printable: your monthly HR-AI health check

☐ No real candidate data pasted un-anonymised ☐ Every screen scored against a written rubric ☐ No auto-rejection ☐ AI use disclosed to candidates ☐ Audit trail kept for shortlisted candidates ☐ Consent notice reviewed by legal ☐ Retention rule applied

Appendix A

Fill-In Templates

Copy these into a document, fill the brackets, and keep them next to the prompts. They turn the method into a repeatable process.

Template 1 — Candidate consent notice (skeleton)

CANDIDATE PRIVACY NOTICE (draft — legal review required) Who we are: [Company name], [address], contact: [email]. What we collect: [itemised list — e.g. name, contact details, résumé, application answers]. Why we process it: to assess your application for [role] and to communicate with you. How long we keep it: [period — confirm with legal]. Automated processing: [state whether AI assists in initial review, and that a human decides]. Your rights: to access, correct or erase your data, and to withdraw consent. To exercise them, contact [contact]. Withdrawal is as easy as giving consent. Complaints: you may complain to the Data Protection Board of India. Languages: this notice is available in English and [language].

Template 2 — Screening rubric and audit-trail log

RUBRIC (one row per criterion) Criterion | Weight | Score 0 (no evidence) | Score 1 (partial) | Score 2 (strong, specific) | Bias-risk flag [criterion 1] | [%] | ... | ... | ... | [low/med/high] [criterion 2] | [%] | ... | ... | ... | [low/med/high] AUDIT TRAIL (one row per candidate) Candidate ID | Role | Date screened | Criteria used | Score per criterion | Source quote(s) | Model and version | Human reviewer | Decision

Template 3 — Interview scorecard

Candidate ID: [ ] Role: [ ] Interviewer: [ ] Date: [ ] Competency | Score 1–5 | Evidence / quote | Concerns [competency 1] | | | [competency 2] | | | [competency 3] | | | Strengths: [ ] Areas to probe further: [ ] Recommendation (advance / hold / no): [ ] Signature: [ ]

Template 4 — The one-page AI-in-HR policy

1. Purpose: how we use AI in people processes, safely and lawfully. 2. Approved tools: [list]. Personal free chatbots are not approved for candidate data. 3. Data rules: never enter names, photos, contact details, or sensitive personal data. Anonymise first. 4. Decisions: AI may draft and rank; a named human decides. No auto-rejection. 5. Disclosure: candidates are told AI assists in initial review. 6. Records: keep an audit trail for every shortlisting decision. 7. Review: this policy is reviewed every [period] by [owner].

Appendix B

Cheat Sheet, Glossary and FAQ

The one-page cheat sheet

Situation	What to do
Writing a job description	Use the rough-brief prompt; map every requirement to an interview stage; run the inclusive-language review.
Screening résumés	Anonymise first; use the evidence-and-quote rubric; never auto-reject.
Building an interview	Use the structured-guide prompt; one competency per question; brief the panel.
Messaging candidates	Warm, specific, honest; no false promises; rejection short and kind.
Onboarding a hire	30-60-90 plan, day-one welcome, week-one buddy, day-30 survey.
A policy or notice	Draft with the prompt, then legal reviews before publishing.
Candidate data and consent	Standalone notice; clear affirmative consent; delete when the purpose ends; rights within 90 days.
Choosing a tool	Free or ₹399 for drafting; business/API for real candidate data; check the Jio offer first.

Glossary

Anonymise — Removing names, photos and contact details from candidate material before it goes into any AI tool.

Audit trail — The per-candidate record of criteria, scores, source text and model version that makes a decision defensible.

Consent (DPDP) — Permission that is free, specific, informed, unconditional and unambiguous, given by a clear affirmative action.

Data Fiduciary — The organisation that decides why and how personal data is processed — in hiring, your company.

Data Principal — The individual the data is about — here, the candidate or employee.

DPDP Act / Rules — India’s Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 and the Rules 2025 that operationalise it.

Evidence-and-quote — The screening method that requires a score plus the exact source sentence justifying it.

High-risk AI (EU) — AI uses the EU AI Act classifies as high-risk, including CV-sorting for recruitment; its obligations apply from 2 December 2027.

Retention period — The defined time after which personal data must be erased once the purpose is served.

Significant Data Fiduciary — A class of larger organisations with extra duties — audits, impact assessments and stricter technology checks.

Frequently asked questions

Can I use a free ChatGPT account for hiring work?

For drafting job descriptions, messages and questions with no real candidate data, yes. For anything containing a real candidate's personal data, use a business, API or enterprise plan your company has approved — and anonymise first.

Is it legal to let AI screen résumés?

AI may help you rank and surface evidence, but keep the rejection decision with a named human and keep an audit trail. Never auto-reject on an AI score, and disclose that AI assists in review.

Do I need candidate consent to process a résumé?

The DPDP Act's employment clause covers employees but not clearly candidates. The cautious, defensible path is a clear notice for every candidate, plus consent for anything beyond the application itself — interview recordings, AI analysis, or keeping a profile for future roles.

When do the DPDP Rules start applying to us?

Most day-to-day duties — notice, breach reporting, retention and erasure — apply from 13 May 2027. Consent Managers must register from 13 November 2026. Treat 2026 as your build year.

Which tool should I buy?

Any capable general assistant runs these prompts. The cheapest paid plans in India are ChatGPT Go and Google AI Plus at ₹399 a month; eligible Jio users can get Google AI Pro free for 18 months. Pick by what data you are allowed to put in it, not by the feature list.

How many prompts are in this playbook?

More than 100, grouped across ten HR jobs — from job descriptions and screening to interviews, onboarding, performance, policies, engagement, learning and HR analytics.

The AI HR & Recruitment Playbook 2026 — India Edition. Published by Digitalaikart. Every adoption figure, tool price and legal date was verified against official sources, government notifications and current vendor pricing in October 2026. Data protection law is fact-specific and changes; confirm the current position and involve your legal team before finalising a consent notice, a retention policy or an automated screening decision. This guide is educational and is not legal advice.